



INDIA'S GROWTH STORY is no longer confined to its bustling metropolises. Smaller towns are stepping into the spotlight, emerging as dynamic contributors to the nation's economy. Fuelled by strategic government initiatives, affordable real estate, and a wave of infrastructure upgrades, cities like Meerut in Uttar Pradesh, Vapi in Gujarat, Haldia in West Bengal, and Tirunelveli in Tamil Nadu are rewriting the script of Tier II city development.

In these cities, prices of real estate have jumped near new infrastructure projects like roads, railway lines, and, perhaps most symbolically, with the arrival of airports.

While challenges persist, the potential for these cities to attract organised players in hospitality, retail, and other sectors is undeniable.

So, what makes these towns tick?

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Meerut, a city once considered a quiet town in Uttar Pradesh, India's most populous state, has undergone a remarkable transformation over the past two decades. Located just 70 km from Noida, which is part of the Delhi-National Capital Region, Meerut is now emerging as a hub for healthcare, education, business, and infrastructure development.

Sudhir Kumar, a 37-year-old bank employee, has lived in Meerut for 20 years, and he has witnessed firsthand the city's dynamic growth. "Twenty years ago," he says, "Meerut was a different place. Now, look at it! Over the years, I've seen Meerut undergo major changes in infrastructure, healthcare, education, and urban planning."

Kumar points towards a gleaming new hospital complex. "Healthcare has been revolutionised. We used to rely on limited facilities, but now, top-notch hospitals attract patients from across the state," he adds. Indeed, there is now the Anand Hospital, Nutima, and the up-graded LLRM medical college.

Over the last decade, ITMS (Integrated Traffic Management System) was introduced in Meerut, including the installation of CCTV cameras at key locations and public areas to monitor traffic violations and enhance security, and a solid waste disposal site has been developed to improve waste management. "Waste collection vehicles come to every area to collect waste from homes. These small changes occurred in our city in the past four

THE STARS

Meerut

It accounts for 3.2% of Uttar Pradesh's GDP. The big industries are textiles, tyres, sugar, chemicals, paper, sports goods, and publishing



ECONOMIC INDICATORS

Gross Domestic Product (GDP):	Per Capita GDP:
\$10 billion	₹ 81,684

DEMOGRAPHIC DYNAMICS

Population:	Literacy rate:
1.85 million	76%

Tirunelveli

The city accounts for 4% of Tamil Nadu's GDP. The big industries are agriculture, wind power, cement, and textiles



ECONOMIC INDICATORS

Gross Domestic Product (GDP):	Per Capita GDP:
\$13 billion	₹ 2.7 lakh

DEMOGRAPHIC DYNAMICS

Population:	Literacy rate:
700,000	75%